

Science Spelling List

A

adviser	Not “advisor.”
adapter; but “adaptor proteins” (7/99)	Not “adaptor.”
affect (v); effect (n)	Effect (v) means to bring about.
alternate/alternative	Use alternate to mean succeeding by turns, alternating in time ("alternate periods of light and dark"). Either is OK to mean a choice between two or more things—follow author.
Alzheimer’s disease	
amphiphilic	
analog	
archaeology	
autoantibody	

B

B cell/T cell (n or adj)	Do not hyphenate whether used as noun or modifier.
bandgap	Always one word
barcode, barcoding	One word
based on	Change to “on the basis of” if used adverbially; but OK if used as adj (e.g. "The map based on data from . . .").
baseline	
base-paired	OK to use as nonpredicate adj (The base-paired xxxx was). Not OK to use as verb or predicate adj (A and C were base-paired); change to “The base A was paired to C,” or “x and y were paired.”
base pairing (n); base-pairing (adj)	
beamline	
beam splitter	
because	Use instead of "since," unless time lapse is meant.
benefited	
binge-like	common parlance in the neuro community (P.R.S.)

blackbody radiation

brainstem

brainwide

bumble bee

2 words

by-product (n)

C

catalog

challenged

OK when referring to immunological challenge (e.g. "mice were challenged with heat-killed virus..."), but replace when applicable with "tested for" or "examined for."

chronic-acute

"Medication was administered chronically-acutely" should be changed to "long-term-short-term administration."

claims

Change; ad hominem.

coexpression

cofactor

cold/hot reagent

Jargon; change to "unlabeled/radiolabeled reagent."

colinear

compare to

Use for favorable comparisons, similarities.

compare with

Use for pointing out differences.

comprise/compose

Use comprise to mean "to include"—the whole comprises the parts—not to mean "make up" (which is compose; the parts compose the whole). "XXX is comprised of" is not correct.

confer on

C terminus (n)

Carboxyl terminus (spell out in abstracts).

C-terminal (adj)

Carboxyl-terminal (spell out in abstracts).

coauthor

coimmunoprecipitation

coinduce

co-receptor

Less confusing

coprecipitates

cotransfected

counterion	
coverslip	
co-worker	
cross-correlation (n)	
crosshatch (n or v)	
cross-hatching (n)	Means process/effect of marking with a crosshatch.
cross-hybridization	
cross-link	
crossing-over (n)	
cross peak	Nuclear magnetic resonance term.
cross-react	
cross section (n); cross-sectional (adj)	
cross-talk	
D	
d-wave	“d” is lowercase and roman (for quantum physics/semiconductor/superconductivity papers)
dark field (n); dark-field (adj)	
data	Takes plural verb.
data bank	
database	
dataset	One word
decision-making	
de-emphasize	
dependent on	Not “dependent upon.”
different from	Not “different than” (see 3rd ed. <i>Words into Type</i> , p. 432).
digoxigenin	Not “digoxigenin. ”
disc	Use only for imaginal disc (as in fly development) or disc gel electrophoresis.
disk (computer)	
DNA binding (adj)	Do not hyphenate when used as a modifier (e.g., DNA binding activity)
down-regulation	

Down syndrome

due to

Replace with “because of,” “as a result of,” “resulting from,” etc. unless “attributable to” is meant.

E

Earth

Capitalize if the planet is meant; do not use “the”

electro-optical

electrophoresed

OK, or use “separated by/subject to electrophoresis.”

email (in text); Email (at start of sentence or line)

employed

Avoid (stuffy); change to “use.”

Enceladus’

Not “Enceladus’s”

endocytosed

OK as jargon; means to undergo endocytosis.

ensure

Does not mean “insure.”

eukaryote

euthanize

Our preferred term, as opposed to “sacrifice” or “kill” (although these are okay if the author has used them).

F

FACScan (Becton-Dickinson)

Brand name.

factor of 2

Use number with “factor.”

farside (n)

lunar farside; but “far side of the Moon.”

fresh water (n); freshwater (adj)

following

Change to “after” when that is what's meant.

forelimb (n and adj)

frameshift

Fruit fly

two words

full-length sense RNA

G

gamma ray (n); gamma-ray (adj)

genome-wide

germ line (n); germline (adj)

germ plasm

Gram-negative/Gram-positive (adj)

gray

groundwater (n or adj)

H

half-life

Hawai‘i

health care (n and adj)

healthy

heatmap

heat shock protein

heat shock transcription factor

hindlimb (n and adj)

high-density (adj)

home page (two words)

homogeneous

homolog

honey bee

hot reagent

hot spot

hotspot

Huntington’s disease

I

ice sheet (n or adj)

impact (n)

in order to

insure

internet

involve

in-frame (adj)

K, L

kilobyte

knock out (v.), knockout (n., adj.)

labeled

least-squares fit

Note ohkina (‘) facing out

Always two words

Does not mean “healthful.”

Hyphenate.

2 words

Change to “radiolabeled XXX.”

Two words for geology.

One word for genetics and all other uses.

Do not use as verb: change to “affect.”

Use “to” usually.

Do not use unless referring to insurance policy.

Lowercase; don’t use “Net.”

Watch; be more precise if possible.

left-hand (adj)

level

Replace with “concentration” or “amount” if not clear.

life cycle

life span (n.) life-span (adj.)

lifestyle

lifetime

line shape

linewidth

Long Covid

initial caps; use “Covid” rather than “COVID” or “COVID-19”

low-density (adj)

Hyphenate but not “very low density”

M

mainframe

majority

Change to “most” if statistical majority is not meant.

Mars’

Not “Mars’s”

modeled

mollusk

Moon/moon

Capitalize when Earth’s Moon is meant; lowercase for other moons.

N

new, novel

Avoid in most contexts, especially biology mss.

N terminus (n)

Amino terminus (spell out in abstracts).

N-terminal (adj)

Amino-terminal (spell out in abstracts)

n-type semiconductor

Roman “n”

non-endemic

non-Hodgkin’s

non-native

non-negotiable

non-nuclear

non–small cell lung cancer

Do not hyphenate “small cell”

now

Not “currently.”

Neanderthal

Not “Neandertal”

nearside (n)

lunar nearside; but “near side of the Moon.”

O

occurred

No preceding hyphen or apostrophe

omics

online

over

Imprecise for amounts; change to “more than.”

P

p-type semiconductor

Roman “p”

p-wave

“p” is lowercase and roman (quantum physics/semiconductor/superconductivity papers)

P wave (n); *P*-wave (adj)

Italicize *P* only when no other variable *P* in the paper (earthquake papers)

phase 1 clinical trial,

Use Arabic numerals

phase 2 clinical trial

phosphorus (n)

Not phosphorous.

PhosphorImager

Brand name.

photocrosslinking

photoinduction

pipette

policy-maker

possess

Change to “have.”

posttranslational

prior to

Stuffy; change to “before.”

prokaryote

proteasome

Not “proteosome”

Q

quasiparticles

quasi-periodic

quasi-spherical

R

radioimmunoassay

radiolabeling

readout (n), readthrough (n)

One word for astronomy; two words for

redshift/red shift

reexamine	nonastronomy papers.
report	Use to refer to <i>Science</i> reports, but for papers in other journals, use “paper” or “study.”
reversed-phase (adj)	Use “d” on end of “reverse,” unless author objects.
riboprobes	Jargon; change to RNA probes.
ride-share, ride-sharing	Always two words
right-hand (adj)	
riverbed	
RNA binding (adj)	Do not hyphenate when used as a modifier (e.g., RNA binding activity)
S	
s-wave	“s” is lowercase and roman (quantum physics/semiconductor/superconductivity papers)
<i>S</i> wave (n); <i>S</i> -wave (adj)	Cap and italic “S” (see <i>P</i> wave notes) (earthquake papers)
sacrifice	Okay, although “euthanize” is preferable. No need to change to “kill.”
salt water (n); saltwater (adj)	
<i>Science</i> NOW	
<i>Science</i> ’s Next Wave	
seabed (n or adj)	Always one word.
seafloor (n and adj)	
sea level (n or adj)	
sea surface (n or adj)	
seawater (n or adj)	
self molecules	
shape-memory alloy	Hyphenate “shape-memory”
sickle cell anemia	
side-chain (adj)	
significant	Use only when statistical significance is meant.
since	Use only to mean time lapse; replace with “because” to indicate causation.

small cell lung cancer
social distancing
solid-state (adj)
Sprague-Dawley rats
stereopair; stereo image
stem-loop
subseafloor (adj)
sulfur
Sun
super predator

super-resolution
supershift, supershifted

T

Talairach coordinates
T cell
TCR α
time point
timescale
topoisomerase
toward
toxicant

toxin

transgender person
tree frog
type 1 diabetes, type 2 diabetes

U

ubiquitinated
ultrahigh/ultralow
underway

Do not hyphenate “small cell”
Always two words

Not sulphur.

Capitalize when Earth’s Sun is meant;
lowercase in other usages.
Two words, always (term for some fauna).
[Single word is a nonscientific social invention
with racist implications]
Not superresolution.

System for mapping the brain.

See B cell note.

T cell receptor α ; close up after defined at first
use.

Now one word (4/13/2023)

Never “towards.”

An environmental pollutant (e.g., pesticides,
industrial chemicals). Not to be confused with
“toxin”

A poisonous substance produced by a living
organism (e.g., snake venom, botulinum toxin).
Not to be confused with “toxicant”
Not “transgendered person” or “a transgender”

Use Arabic numerals

Means conjugated with ubiquitin.

Always one word

unique	Avoid, except in mathematical sense of unique.
United Kingdom (n); UK (n or adj)	Noun form may be spelled out or abbreviated. But spell out noun form in abstracts.
United States (n); US (n or adj)	Noun form may be spelled out or abbreviated. But spell out noun form in abstracts.
upon	Change to “on” if applicable.
up-regulation (n)	
using, by using	Change to “with” or “by” when used without an antecedent that is capable of doing the using.
V	
van der Waals interaction	
via	Avoid unless “by way of” is meant; otherwise replace with “through” or “by means of.”
W	
waveform	Do not follow AIP.
wavefront	Do not follow AIP.
wave function	Follow AIP.
waveguide	
wavelength	
wave number	
wave packet	
wave vector	
web, website	
whether	Avoid “whether or not” and “as to whether”; use in place of “if” in statement such as “We sought to determine whether...”
while	Replace with “whereas” or “although”; use “while” only for actions occurring simultaneously.
within	Usually change to “in.”
whole-cell extracts	
whole-cell patch-clamp recording	
Wilms tumor	
workforce	

World Wide Web

Use "Web" subsequently.

worldwide (adj)

workstation

X

x axis, *y* axis (n); *x*-axis, *y*-axis (adj)

x-ray

Lowercase; use "X-ray" in titles.

Z

zinc finger domain

Z line